RICE UNIVERSITY

Multi-Server Communication

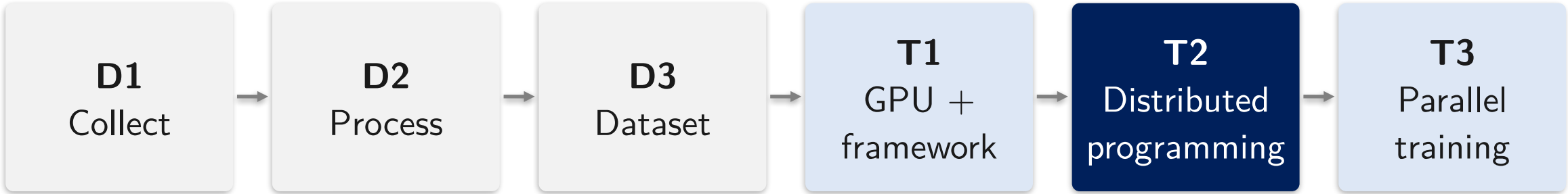
Topology, launching, hangs, and an α–β model of the network between servers

Yuke Wang

Rice University

COMP 329 · Spring 2027 · Week 11, Lecture 2

Where we are in the pipeline



In our pipeline

Today: collectives **across servers**, and the guided **two-server** benchmark with an α–β **fit** (Lab 4, due after this lecture).

Last time: NCCL collectives inside one server $\rightarrow$ today: what changes between servers

Learning goals for today

- **Describe** what connects GPUs **inside** a server and **between** servers, and how fast each link is.
- **Explain** why the **slowest link** sets the pace, and how a **hierarchical** all-reduce avoids it.
- **Explain** how a job starts on two servers, and the two common reasons it **hangs**.
- **Fit** an α–β model to two-server measurements and use it to predict.

A puzzle to start

Each GPU holds 1 GB of gradients; all-reduce them.

A: 8 GPUs in one server. B: 16 GPUs in two servers.

Is B faster, about the same, or slower than A?

Answer

Slower. A $\approx$ 3.9 ms; B $\approx$ **37.5 ms** — about **10×** slower, with twice the GPUs.

Source: Model estimates. NVLink: H100 datasheet; network: 400 Gb/s NDR InfiniBand NIC (typical).

Recap: the α–β model

- α (latency): the fixed start-up cost of one message.
- β (bandwidth): the bytes per second a link moves.

$$\text{one message of } n \text{ bytes:} \quad T = \alpha + n \,/\, \beta$$

$$\text{ring all-reduce on } p \text{ GPUs, large } n: \quad T \approx 2(p-1)/p \cdot n \,/\, \beta$$

Watch out

Last lecture every link had the **same** β. Across servers they do not — which β do we use?

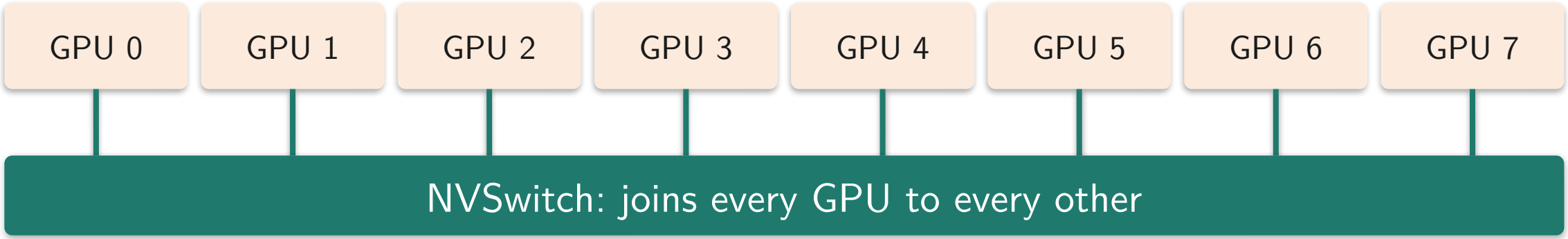
Part 1

Inside and between servers

What connects the GPUs, and how fast is each link?

Inside one server

8 GPUs in one server



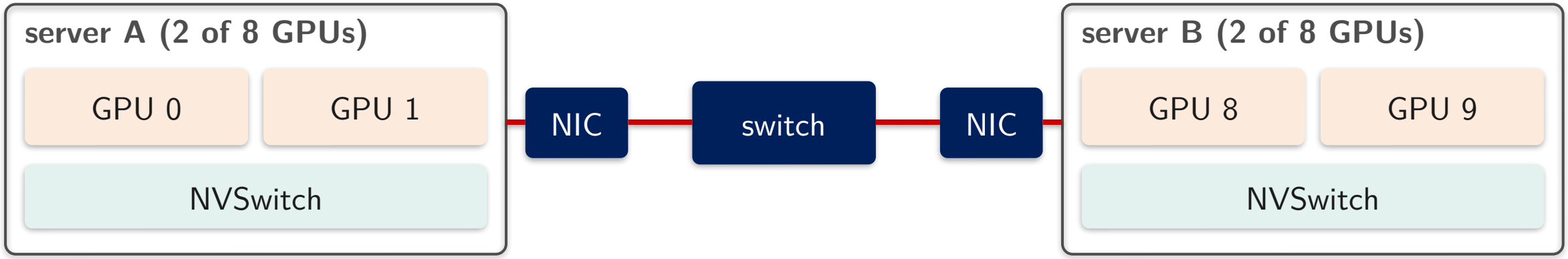
NVLink: **450 GB/s** each way, for every GPU

Key idea

NVLink: direct wires between GPUs. **NVSwitch**: a switch chip that joins them, so any two GPUs in the server talk at full speed.

Source: NVIDIA DGX H100 datasheet and user guide (8 × H100, 4 NVSwitch chips, 8 × ConnectX-7 at 400 Gb/s); H100 datasheet.

Leaving the server: the network card



each NIC: **400 Gb/s** (a typical server has one per GPU)

$$400 \text{ Gb/s} \div 8 \text{ bits per byte} = 50 \text{ GB/s}$$

Key idea

NIC (network interface card): puts bytes on the cable. A **switch** forwards them to the right server. Network speeds are in **bits**: divide by 8.

Source: Typical NIC: 400 Gb/s NDR InfiniBand (InfiniBand Trade Association); NVLink: H100 datasheet (900 GB/s bidirectional).

The gap: leaving the server is slow

per GPU, each way



Watch out

Leaving the server is **9× slower**. Every byte that crosses servers pays for it.

Source: Typical NIC: 400 Gb/s NDR InfiniBand (InfiniBand Trade Association); NVLink: H100 datasheet (900 GB/s bidirectional).

Check yourself

Two minutes with a neighbour.

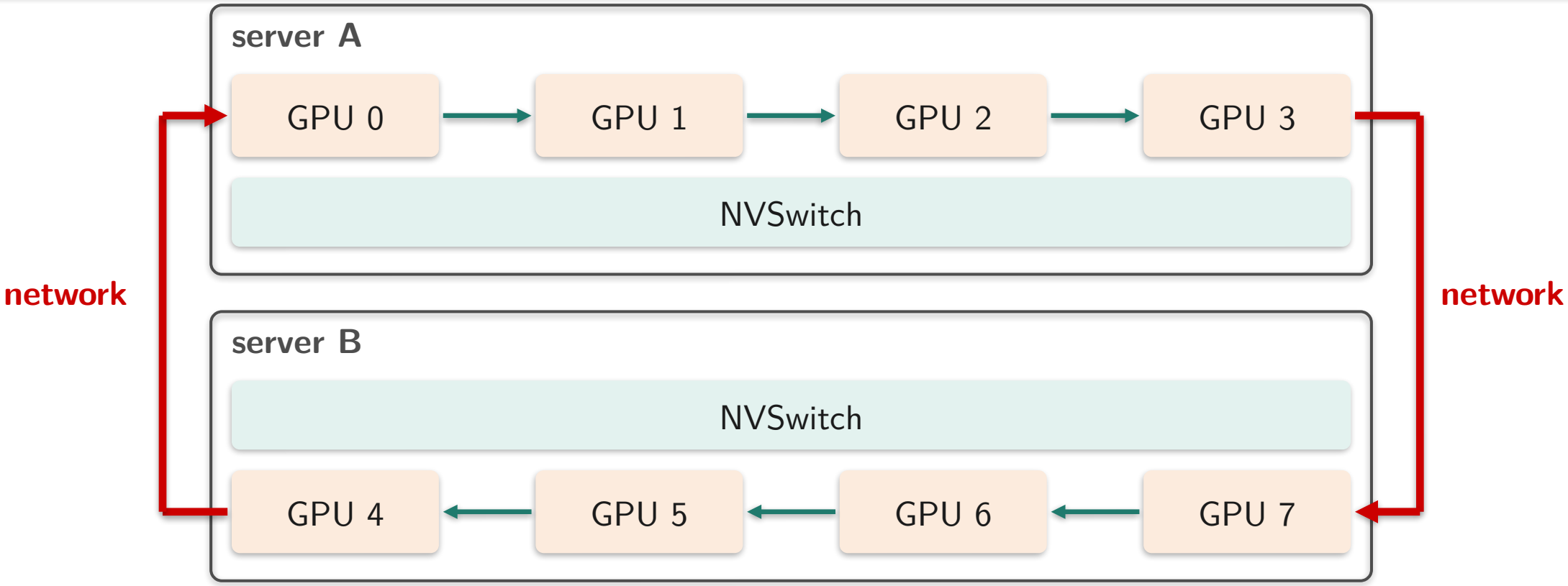
- A cluster has 200 Gb/s NICs. How many GB/s is that? How many times slower than NVLink?
- GPU 0 sends to GPU 5 in the same server, then to a GPU in another server. Which links?
- Why is a server with **one** NIC for 8 GPUs a problem?

Part 2

The slowest link sets the pace

If one link is 9× slower, how should the all-reduce change?

A flat ring across two servers



Key idea

Flat ring: one ring through all GPUs. Six hops are fast NVLink, two are the slow network.

The slowest link sets the pace

- In every step, **all** GPUs send one piece at the same time.
- The step ends when the **slowest** send ends; the others wait.

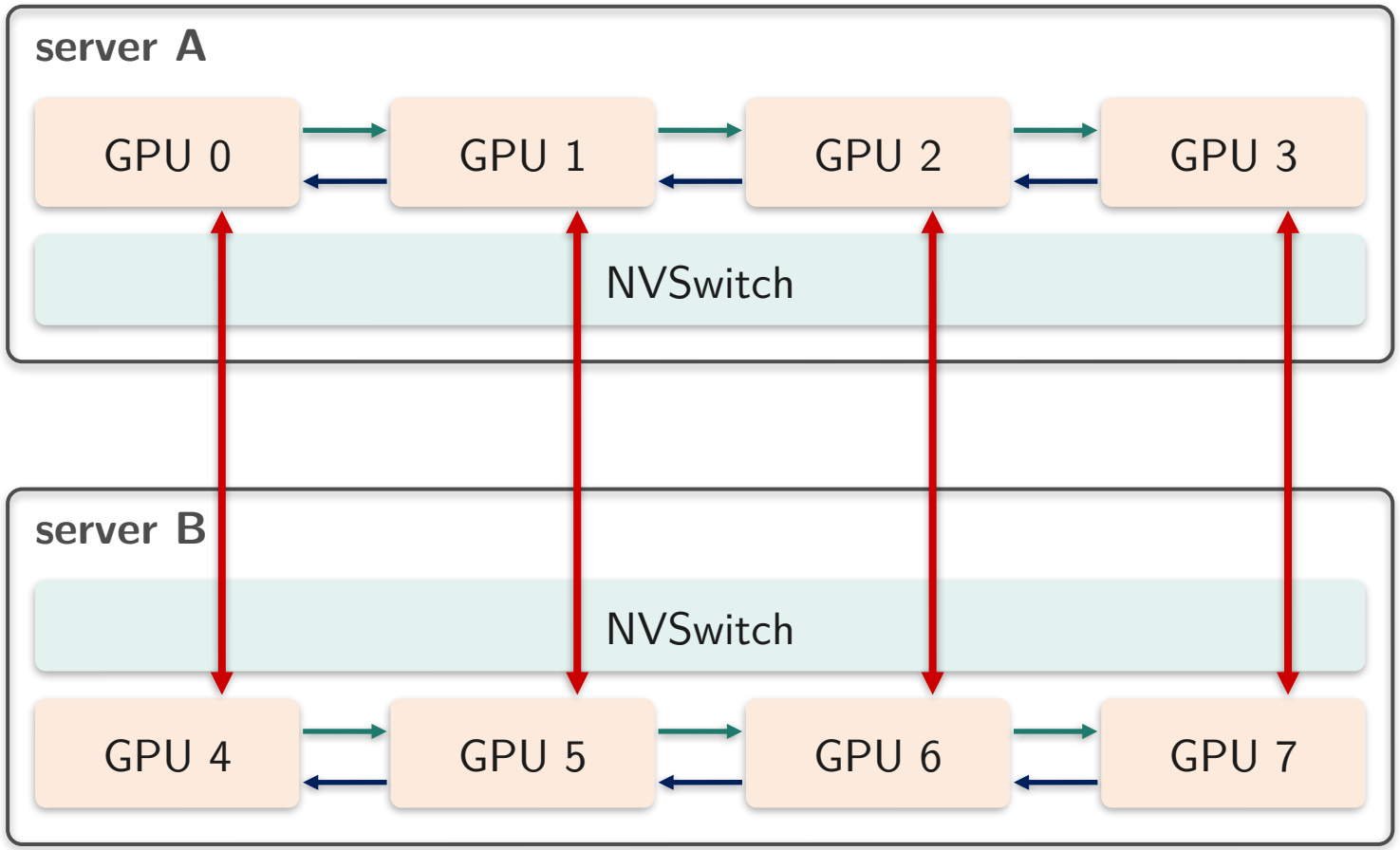
$$T \approx 2(p-1)/p \cdot n \;/\; \beta(\text{slowest})$$

Result

Puzzle B: $\beta(\text{slowest}) = 50$ GB/s, so T $\approx$ **37.5 ms**. The fast links sit idle most of each step.

Source: Typical NIC: 400 Gb/s NDR InfiniBand (InfiniBand Trade Association); NVLink: H100 datasheet (900 GB/s bidirectional).

Hierarchical all-reduce: three phases



1 · reduce-scatter inside each server (NVLink)

2 · the k-th GPUs of A and B all-reduce slice k, each on its own NIC

3 · all-gather inside each server (NVLink)

Key idea

Each NIC carries only $\mathbf{1/g}$ of the data (g = GPUs per server).

One worked number: the puzzle again

puzzle B: 16 GPUs in two servers, 8 per server, 1 GB each



total $\approx$ **6.4 ms**

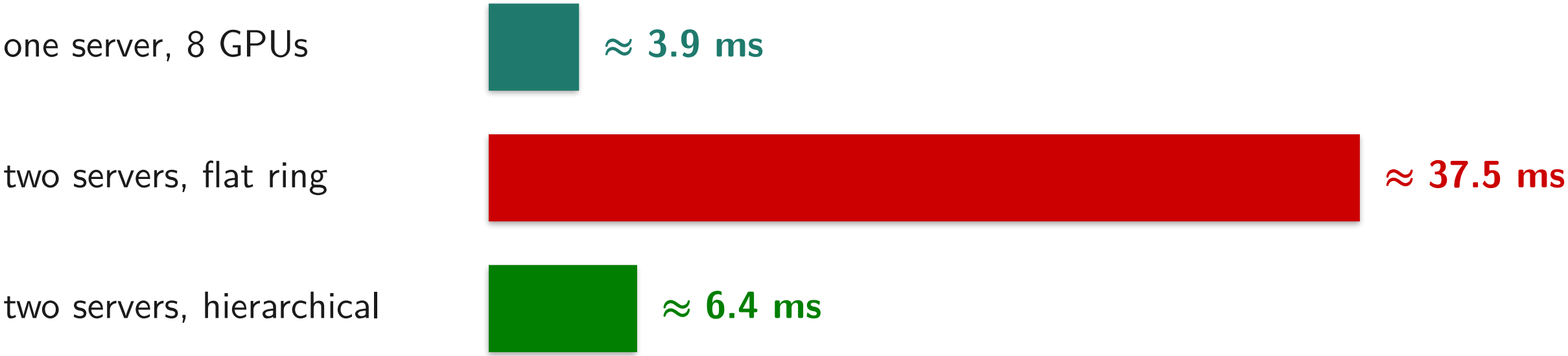
network phase: each NIC carries 1 GB $\div$ 8 $\rightarrow$ 2.5 ms

Why it works

Most of the work moves to NVLink. The slow network carries only **1/8** of the data per NIC.

Source: Typical NIC: 400 Gb/s NDR InfiniBand (InfiniBand Trade Association); NVLink: H100 datasheet (900 GB/s bidirectional). Model estimate.

Back to the puzzle



Answer

A server-aware algorithm recovers most of the speed — **if** each GPU has its own NIC. NCCL does this for you.

Source: Typical NIC: 400 Gb/s NDR InfiniBand (InfiniBand Trade Association); NVLink: H100 datasheet (900 GB/s bidirectional). Model estimates.

Check yourself

Two minutes with a neighbour.

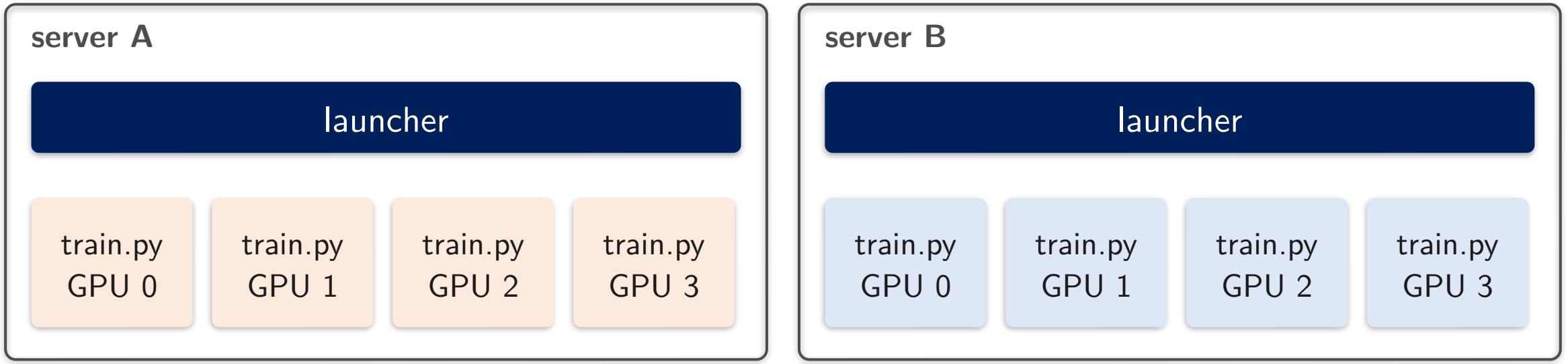
- Redo the hierarchical estimate with **200 Gb/s** NICs (one per GPU).
- Why does a flat ring across two servers waste NVLink?
- Which traffic would you keep **inside** a server: the frequent or the rare?

Part 3

Launching, and why jobs hang

How do processes on two machines find each other?

The same program on every server



one command, typed on each server (or run by the cluster's scheduler)

Key idea

Launcher: starts one copy of your script per GPU and tells each copy **who it is**.

Source: PyTorch documentation, torch.distributed and torchrun (v2.9).

Who am I? Node rank and local rank

node rank: which server · **local rank**: which GPU inside it

server A · **node rank 0**

rank 0	**rank 1**	**rank 2**	**rank 3**
local 0	local 1	local 2	local 3
GPU 0	GPU 1	GPU 2	GPU 3

server B · **node rank 1**

rank 4	**rank 5**	**rank 6**	**rank 7**
local 0	local 1	local 2	local 3
GPU 0	GPU 1	GPU 2	GPU 3

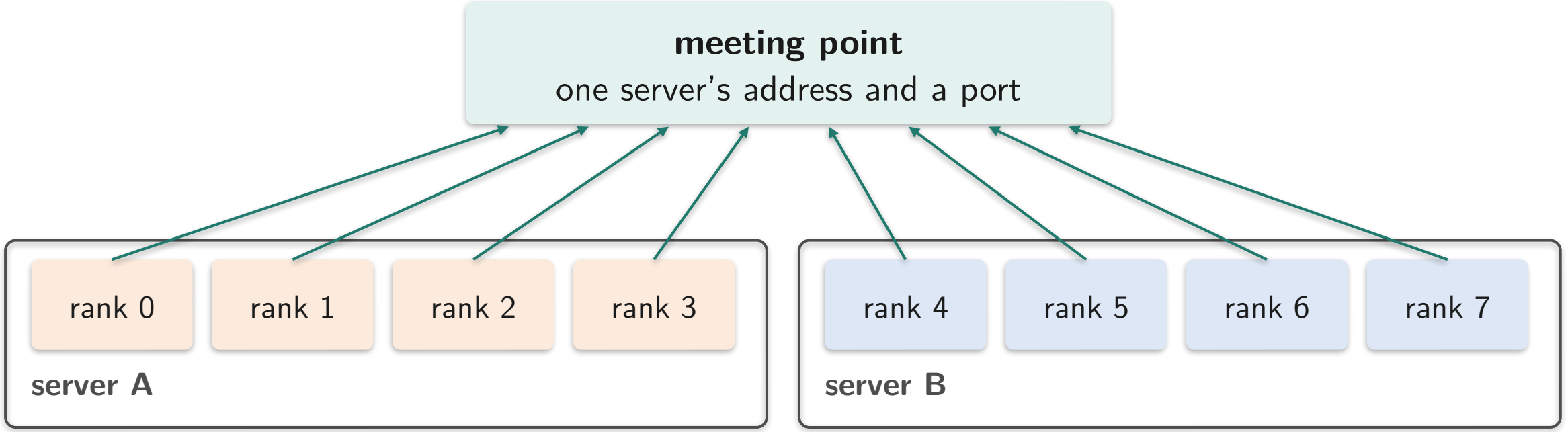
$$\text{rank} = \text{node rank} \times 4 + \text{local rank}$$

Key idea

Example: node 1, local rank 2 $\rightarrow$ rank $1 \times 4 + 2 = \mathbf{6}$, on GPU 2. The **world size** is the number of processes: 8.

Source: PyTorch documentation, torch.distributed and torchrun (v2.9).

Finding each other: a meeting point



each waits until **all 8** have arrived; then the job starts

Watch out

Timeout: how long a process waits before giving up with an error. If one server never starts, the others stop at the timeout.

Source: PyTorch documentation, torch.distributed and torchrun (v2.9).

The first lines of every script

```
local = int(os.environ["LOCAL_RANK"])
torch.cuda.set_device(local)      # my GPU
dist.init_process_group(          # meet
    "nccl", timeout=timedelta(minutes=5))
rank = dist.get_rank()            # 0 .. 7
print(rank, local, socket.gethostname())
```

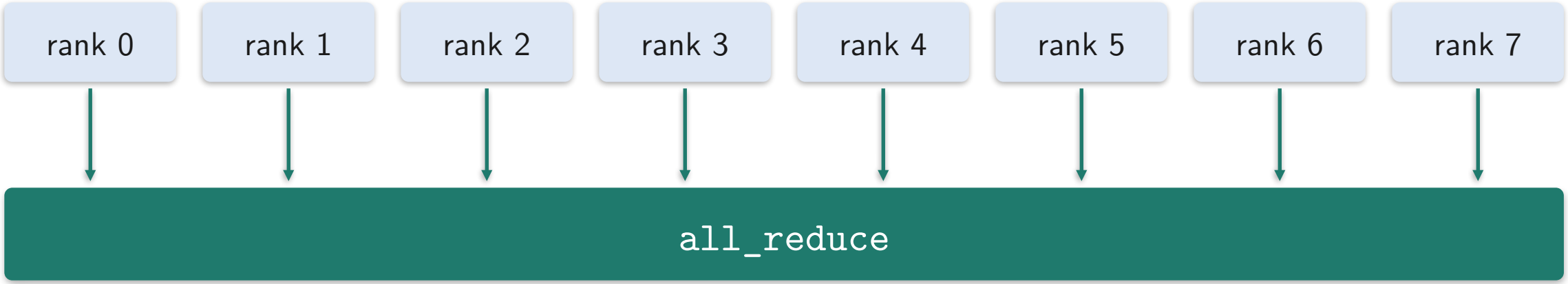
- Same file on one server or two.
- A **short** timeout: mistakes show up fast.
- Print who runs **where**.

In our pipeline

Lab 4, step 1: a table of rank, local rank, server, and GPU for **every** process.

Source: PyTorch documentation, torch.distributed and torchrun (v2.9).

A collective is a meeting

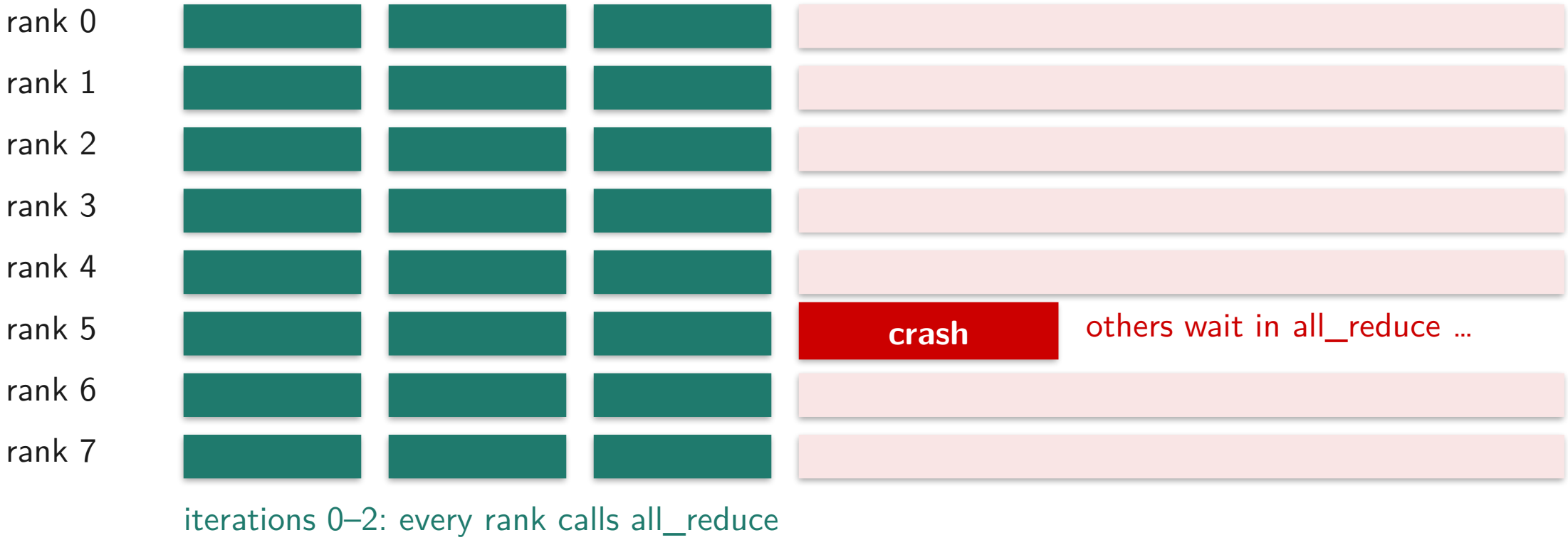


nobody leaves until **everyone** has arrived

Watch out

Hang: no error, no progress. Some rank never arrives — or arrives at a **different** collective.

Hang 1: a crashed rank



Watch out

Read the log of the **first rank that failed**; the others only report the timeout.

Hang 2: a different order of calls

	ranks 0–6		rank 7 (old copy of the code)
call 1	`all_reduce(grads)`	↔	`all_reduce(loss)`
call 2	`all_reduce(grads)`		`all_reduce(grads)`

call 1 meets call 1: gradients paired with a loss → hang or wrong sums

The rule

Every rank must call the **same collectives** in the **same order**, with the same sizes.

A short debugging checklist

- **Start small**: 2 GPUs on one server, then 1 GPU on each of two servers.
- **Print** rank, local rank, server, and GPU from every process.
- **Same code and software** on every server.
- **Count collectives**: does every rank reach the same call?
- On a timeout, read the **first rank that failed**.

Source: NVIDIA NCCL User Guide: Environment Variables; Troubleshooting.

Check yourself

Two minutes with a neighbour.

- 4 processes per server. Which rank and GPU does local rank 3 on node 1 get?
- Seven ranks print "step 41"; rank 2 has printed nothing since step 40. Where do you look?
- Only rank 0 runs `all_reduce(loss)` to print the loss. What happens?

IN-CLASS BUILD

Two-server benchmark and α–β fit

Design it in pairs now; run it in Lab 4.

Exercise A: design the two-server benchmark

intra
2 GPUs in one server
link: NVLink

inter
1 GPU on each of two servers
link: the network

QUESTIONS

(1) Why use exactly 2 GPUs in **both** runs?

(2) Which message sizes, from smallest to largest?

(3) How many repetitions, and which time do you report?

Solutions A: the design

- (1) Same work in both runs: **only the link differs**.
- (2) **Tiny to very large**, spaced evenly on a log scale, so both α and β show.
- (3) Warm up, time **many** runs, report the **slowest rank**; repeat the sweep.

In our pipeline

This is the guided two-server part of **Lab 4** and **T2**.

Fitting α and β: a straight line

$$T(n) = \alpha + n \,/\, \beta$$

```
n = np.array(sizes, float)          # bytes
t = np.array(times)                 # seconds
A = np.stack([np.ones_like(n), n], axis=1)
w = 1 / t                           # weights
(a, b), *_ = np.linalg.lstsq(A * w[:, None],
                             t * w, rcond=None)
alpha, beta = a, 1 / b
```

RESULT

Weight each point by $\mathbf{1/t}$. Without it the largest messages decide, and α comes out wrong.

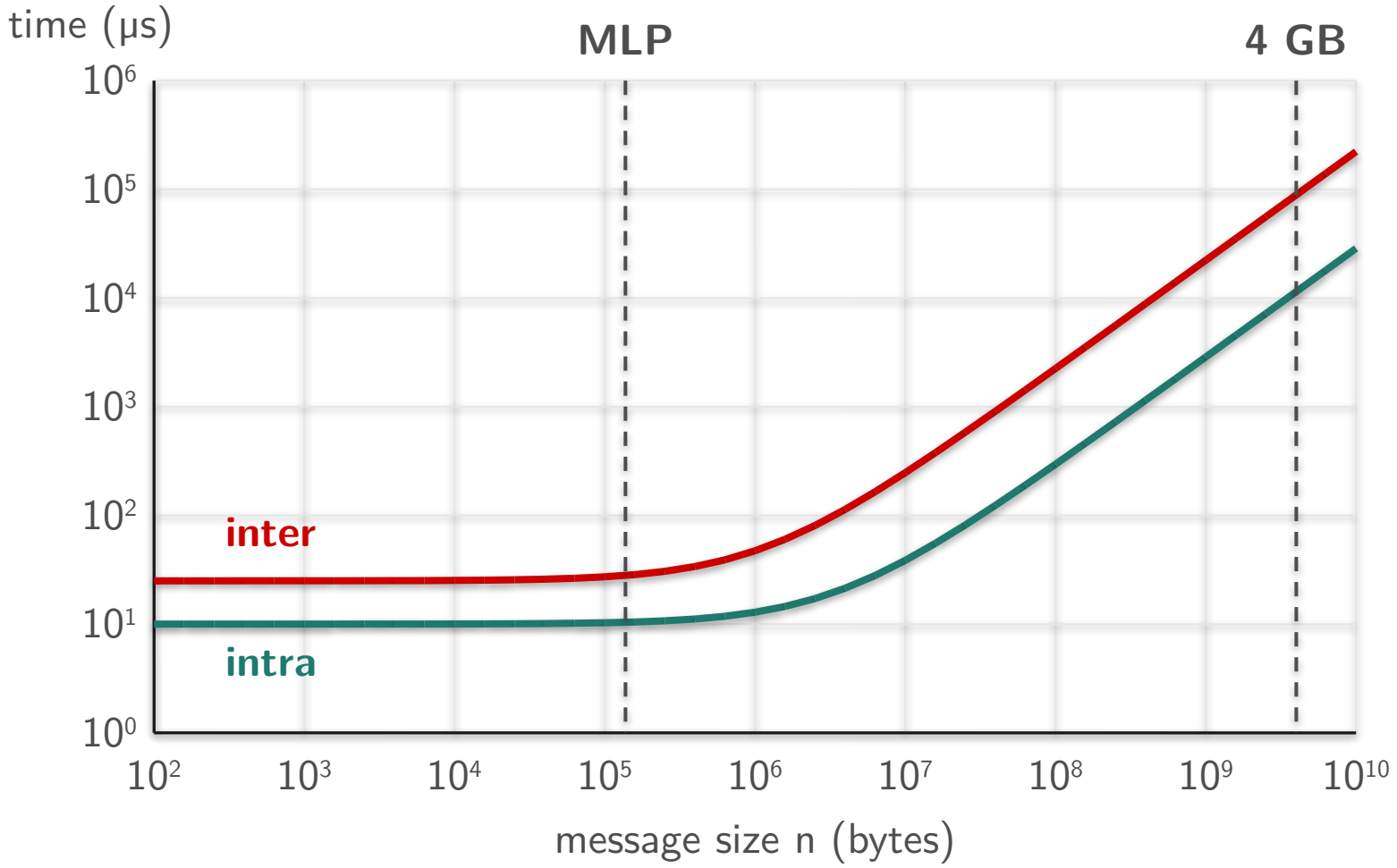
Exercise B: predict with a fit

GIVEN

Inter-server fit: $\alpha = 25$ µs, $\beta = 45$ GB/s

- (1) Our MLP's gradient, 137,352 bytes: how long?
- (2) A 4 GB gradient: how long?
- (3) Which term, α or n/β, decides each answer?

What the two fits look like



READ IT

Flat: time $\approx \alpha$.

Sloped: time $\approx n/\beta$.

The bend is at

$\mathbf{n^* = \alpha \cdot \beta}$.

Source: Model curves with assumed parameters, not measurements; replace with your Lab 4 fits.

Solutions B: latency or bandwidth

- (1) MLP: $\approx$ **28 µs** — almost all α.
- (2) 4 GB: $\approx$ **89 ms** — almost all $\mathbf{n}/\beta$.
- (3) Small messages pay for **latency**; large ones pay for **bandwidth**.

Check

Know your regime **before** optimizing: compare the message size n with $n^* = \alpha \cdot \beta$.

Lab 4: what to hand in

- The **rank table**: rank, local rank, server, GPU for every process.
- Two sweeps, **intra** and **inter**, with the same sizes and harness.
- α **and** β for each link, a log–log plot, and the two predictions.

In our pipeline

Report the **gap** between intra and inter, and explain it with α, β, and the topology.

Key takeaways

- Inside a server: **NVLink**, 450 GB/s per GPU. Between servers: a **NIC**, 50 GB/s — 9× slower.
- A ring runs at the speed of its **slowest link**.
- **Hierarchical** all-reduce: most work on NVLink; each NIC carries only 1/g of the data.
- Launch the **same script** on every server; rank = node rank × GPUs per server + local rank.
- Hangs: a **crashed rank**, or ranks calling collectives in a **different order**.
- Fit $\mathbf{T = \alpha + n/\beta}$ per link; $n^* = \alpha \cdot \beta$ separates latency- from bandwidth-bound.

Next time, and readings

When	What
After this lecture	Lab 4 due
Week 12	T2 due; T3 out
Week 12, Lecture 1	Data parallelism: many GPUs, one averaged gradient

READ BEFORE WEEK 12

PyTorch *Distributed Overview* and the DDP tutorial.

NCCL User Guide: *Troubleshooting*.